

point, and it costs nothing. The home kitchen is the best performance kitchen a young athlete can have. The everyday meals our mothers and grandmothers cook — dal with rice, a vegetable with roti, curd on the side, a fruit, an egg, a glass of milk — are quietly brilliant sports food. They are fresh, balanced and familiar, and the body recognises them.

I will take a warm, home-cooked thali over a fancy packaged bar any day of the week. And try to get something into them within an hour

of finishing a hard session, when the body is most ready to rebuild.

Hydration is the other thing we lose, quite literally, in our heat. Young athletes do not cool themselves as efficiently as adults, and they often forget to drink until they are already behind. Training in the afternoon sun without enough fluid is how you end up with cramps, dizziness and a child who simply gives up early. Water through the day, not just at practice, matters. And after a long, sweaty session, a pinch

More is good: The first rule is simple: feed the growth first, then the sport. A teenage athlete needs more food than an adult, not less. GETTY IMAGES

of salt, lemon and sugar in water goes a long way. Coconut water is a gift. Use it.

I will end with a warning I find myself repeating every single week: please do not hand adult diet culture to a child.

No skipping meals to make a weight category in a hurry. No fat-loss plans for a body that is supposed to be growing. No fancy supplements to replace a meal that mum has already made.

The pressure these kids carry — from coaches, from social media, from us — is heavy enough without us teaching them to fear food.

Get this stage right and you are not just building a better player for next season. You are building a healthy adult who happens to be strong, with bones that last, blood that carries oxygen properly and a relationship with food that will not betray them at 25.

Feed them enough. Feed them real. Check their iron and calcium. Keep water close. And trust the home kitchen more than the supplement aisle.

Do that, and the talent you are so proud of will finally have the foundation it deserves.

